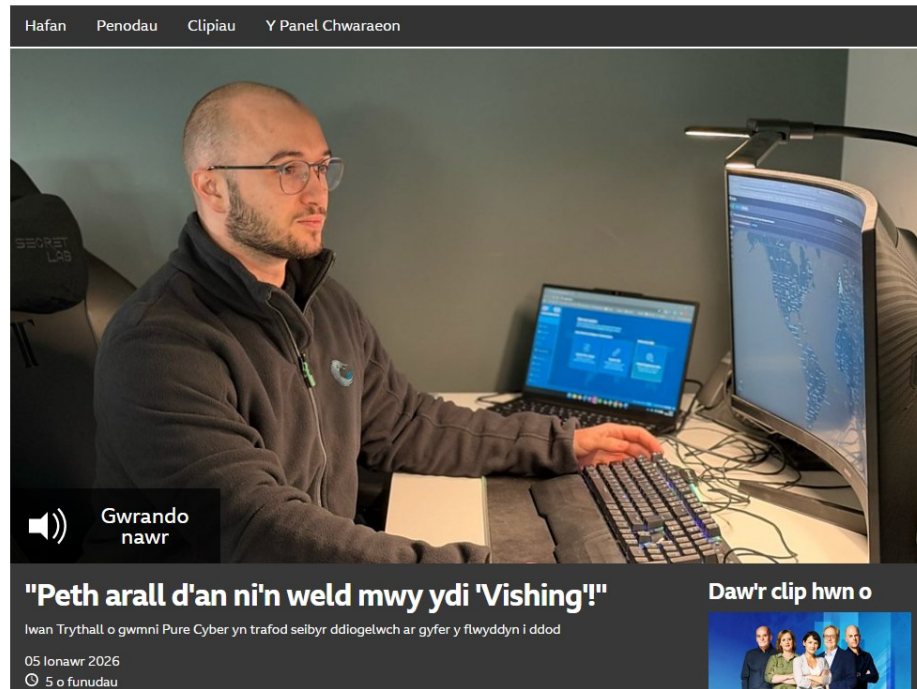


BBC Radio Cymru: Cyber Security Interview

With Rhodri Llywelyn | January 2025



<https://www.bbc.co.uk/programmes/p0ms6957>

Overview

In January 2025, I was invited onto BBC Radio Cymru to discuss the future of cyber security in 2026 with presenter Rhodri Llywelyn. The conversation covered emerging threats and practical steps that people and organisations can take to stay safe. It was broadcast in Welsh to a general public audience, so a big part of the challenge was making quite technical topics feel understandable and relevant to everyday people.

Key Topics Discussed

Phishing: Boring but Still the Biggest Threat

Phishing is probably not what most people picture when they think about getting hacked, but it is still the most common way it actually happens. It works because it goes after human behaviour rather than technical weaknesses in systems. No matter how good your software is, if someone clicks a convincing link or hands over their credentials, the attacker is in. Awareness and a healthy dose of scepticism remain the best defences most people have.

AI Phishing and Vishing: A More Convincing Threat

AI is making phishing attacks noticeably harder to spot. Attackers can now generate well-written, contextually convincing messages at scale without much effort. The bigger concern though is vishing, where AI is used to clone a person's voice well enough to impersonate someone the target trusts, whether that is a colleague, a manager, or even a family member. Once you start questioning whether the voice on the other end of a phone call is real, it changes how you think about a lot of everyday interactions.

A Small Advantage for Welsh Speakers

This was one of the more interesting points in the discussion. AI voice cloning and language generation tools are much less refined in Welsh than in English, simply because there is far less Welsh language training data available. That means a Welsh-speaking target is more likely to notice something off about an AI-generated voice or message in Welsh. It is a small advantage, but a genuine one, and it is worth being aware of.

Learning to Spot AI-Generated Content

As AI-generated content becomes more common, people are starting to develop an instinct for recognising it, similar to how an older generation learned to spot obvious spam emails. Some of the tell-tale signs in written content include overly formal sentence structures, oddly placed punctuation, and a lack of anything genuinely personal or specific. In phishing emails in particular, patterns like unusual punctuation choices are starting to be picked up on as red flags. This growing public awareness is actually a useful layer of protection.

Ransomware: What It Is and Why It Works

For a general audience, ransomware can be explained pretty simply. Attackers get into your system, lock your files using encryption so you cannot open them, and then demand payment, usually in cryptocurrency, in return for the key to unlock everything. Ransomware groups are increasingly organised and tend to go after businesses rather than individuals because the potential payouts are much larger. The key thing to understand is that paying does not guarantee you get your files back, which is why having offline backups is one of the most important things anyone can do.

Prediction: Agentic AI in Cyber Attacks

During the interview I predicted that the following 12 months would see a rise in the use of agentic AI by attackers. This refers to AI that can carry out multi-step attack processes on its own, with minimal human involvement, handling things like reconnaissance, crafting targeted messages, and moving through a network autonomously. Looking at where things stand in 2026, that prediction has held up. Early real-world examples of this kind of automated attack behaviour are already beginning to surface.

Reflection

Being asked to speak on BBC Radio Cymru was something I was genuinely proud of. Cyber security is a topic that does not get discussed enough in Welsh, and getting to break it down for a Welsh-speaking audience felt worthwhile. Explaining technical threats in plain language, in Welsh, is harder than it sounds, and it pushed me to think carefully about how to make these topics feel relevant to people who are not working in the field. That kind of communication is something I want to keep developing.